

The Battle of Gettysburg

Decide whether the three-day battle of July 1863 — together with Vicksburg — was the turning point that changed the direction of the Civil War.

? Historical challenge

In July 1863, Confederate General Robert E. Lee invaded the North and met the Union army at Gettysburg, Pennsylvania, in the largest battle ever fought in North America. Why do historians call this three-day battle a turning point of the Civil War? Map what led up to it and what changed afterward.

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

Gettysburg Overview – Gettysburg National Military Park (NPS)

SECONDARY SOURCE

The three days of battle and their staggering cost.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How many casualties did the battle produce?
- Why was the outcome so important?

SOURCES 2

The Gettysburg Address – Library of Congress

PRIMARY SOURCE

Lincoln's short speech dedicating the cemetery months after the battle.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How did Lincoln describe the meaning of the war?
- Why give such a speech at a battlefield cemetery?

SOURCES 3

Emancipation Proclamation – National Archives

PRIMARY SOURCE

The January 1863 order that reframed the war's purpose.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How did the Proclamation change the war's meaning?
- How does it connect to the Gettysburg Address?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.

BEFORE

After his victory at Chancellorsville, Lee held the momentum, and the war's major fighting sat in Virginia.



PRESSURES BUILDING

Lee launched a second invasion of the North to carry the war off Virginia's farmland and onto Union soil, hoping a decisive victory would push the Union toward negotiation and win foreign recognition.



TURNING POINT

The Battle of Gettysburg · July 1–3, 1863

Over three days the armies clashed; on July 3, Lee's massed assault (Pickett's Charge) on the Union center was repulsed with heavy losses.



IMMEDIATE RESULTS

Lee's invasion failed and he retreated to Virginia; the battle produced about 51,000 casualties, the most of any Civil War battle.



LONGER-TERM CHANGE

Paired with the fall of Vicksburg (July 4, 1863), momentum shifted decisively to the Union; the Gettysburg Address (Nov. 1863) reframed the war around 'a new birth of freedom.'

Who pushed toward this point?

Lee and the Confederate commanders, gambling on an offensive invasion of the North.

Who resisted?

General Meade and the Army of the Potomac, holding the high ground on the defensive.

Could events have gone differently?

Had the Confederates seized Little Round Top or Cemetery Hill on July 2, the Union line — and the outcome — might have broken.

Why could this be a turning point?

Using cause and effect, explain how the Union victory at Gettysburg — together with Vicksburg — changed the direction of the Civil War. Cite one immediate result and one longer-term change.

Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3 Compare

- Compare your before-and-after with a partner. Did you agree on what changed most?
- Which pressure do you think mattered most in leading to the battle?

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

TEACHER NOTE

Key ideas

Gettysburg (July 1–3, 1863) was Lee's second, most ambitious invasion of the North. Meade's Union army held the high ground; Pickett's Charge on July 3 failed. With ~51,000 casualties and Lee's retreat — plus the fall of Vicksburg on July 4 — the war's momentum shifted to the Union. The Gettysburg Address (Nov. 19, 1863) recast the war around freedom and self-government.

Common misconceptions

- Gettysburg did not end the war; it shifted momentum, alongside Vicksburg.
- The casualty figure (~51,000) counts killed, wounded, captured, and missing — not only deaths.
- The Gettysburg Address came months after the battle, at the cemetery dedication.

Vocabulary

invasion, Army of Northern Virginia, Army of the Potomac, Pickett's Charge, casualties, Emancipation Proclamation, momentum.

Historical context

July 1–3, 1863; Lee vs. Meade; Pickett's Charge July 3; ~51,000 casualties; Vicksburg fell July 4, 1863; Gettysburg Address Nov. 19, 1863.

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Was Gettysburg truly a turning point? Use evidence from at least two sources to argue what changed after it — pairing it with Vicksburg — that could not be undone.